

— LEADERSHIP COACHING · V2

My Reflection

What I learned, the strengths I'm building on, what I've put into practice — and my feedback to you.

Nihir Kumar • Sessions 0 – 10 • with Christiana Mitcheva • Closing session • 23 September 2026

Five things I want to walk you through

01 What I've learned

Feedback, trust, influence, change
— and myself

02 Strengths I'm building on

What you reflected back to me

03 What I've put into practice

Done · practising · growth edges

04 My feedback to you

What helped — and a suggestion

05 To close

Where do you see me differently?

— 01 WHAT I'VE LEARNED

On giving feedback

Ask first, and make room

Ask permission before giving feedback, and **book the time** for it — never drop it in passing.

Speak in the "I" form

I observed, I noticed, in my perception — the moment I say *you did*, the other person defends.

Be concrete, not generic

Vague feedback — even when positive — creates **suspicion** rather than value.

Keep it flowing — "what else?"

When they open up, "**what else? what else?**" draws out the real message — used with dosage.

The inner stance carries

Most of what lands is nonverbal. I have to find something I **genuinely respect** before I start.

Three kinds of receiver

One owns it; one needs **several rounds**; one goes into denial and can't be pushed.

— 01 WHAT I'VE LEARNED

On trust

- **Trust is the foundation.** Feedback only works if the person already sees me as credible — the base of the pyramid, the first of the seven criteria. Most relevant with the *Core team*, where my credibility is still forming.
- **The iceberg.** Only a quarter of a person is visible. Needs, fears and mood sit under the surface — to move someone I have to understand what really drives them, not just what I see.
- **Constructive beats comfortable.** Critical-but-constructive feedback is where I learn most — it tells me what people expect and how they'd do it. "Thank you — what else?" keeps it open.

— 01 WHAT I'VE LEARNED

On influence & stakeholders

- **Lead with the value to them**, not with my team's pain. The pain opens the door — the value is what carries. This changed the cross-team meeting and the dashboard presentation.
- **Real influence is when they own the idea themselves** — the biggest shift for me, given my low influence score.
- **Ask each stakeholder how they want to be informed.** Christiana and Amauri differ — email, a short 1:1, a message. Map them by interest and power, per initiative.
- **Stated agreement is not commitment.** Set a deadline and a proactive check, rather than waiting for something to break.

— 01 WHAT I'VE LEARNED

On leading change & leading people

- A rule is adopted only if it's **concrete, valued by the team, and run as a small time-boxed pilot**. Small steps beat big initiatives.
- **Situational leadership.** New to the context always starts with direction — however senior the person — then I step back as they learn.
- **It's about the people, not me.** I'm only as good as my team is — so I deliver even hard news in "*we*" language, calmly and without fear.
- **Language carries weight.** *And / nevertheless* instead of *but*; *when* instead of *if*; and never the words *never* and *always*.

— 01 WHAT I'VE LEARNED

On myself

DISC · MY ANCHOR

High steadiness

THE GROWTH EDGE

Low influence

- I lead by **pulling people with me, not pushing** — it's who I am, and it's how I build trust. The art is sensing *when* a moment also needs a push.
- I'm motivated more by **constructive challenge than by praise** — and I'm learning not to project that onto people who need encouragement instead.
- My state can show before I speak — so I *name it to tame it*: "I hear you, I decide not to react right now," then choose my response deliberately.

What's already working

Reflected back to me over ten sessions.

Structure

More than dashboards — I bring structure to **behaviour and leading by example**. You said it's exactly the structure my people need.

Visual thinking is my language

When a decision needs weight, I build a picture. Dashboards are how I **communicate and lead** — and the product head wanted the last one taken wider.

Problem → solution

I take a failure, gather the picture from every corner, and turn it into a **concrete 20-point plan** across product, engineering and country managers.

The observer's read

I contribute best by **observing, collecting and re-presenting clearly** — and I know people shift the moment they're observed.

And the reflection itself

You said you were even prouder that I **mapped honestly where the gaps still are** — that the reflecting is the hard work, and I'm willing to do it.

What I've put into practice

DONE DEMONSTRATED

- DISC, interest–power stakeholder map, skill–interest team matrix
- Value–first framing — real buy-in; the product head wanted the dashboard taken wider
- Routing up through **Daniel** first — asking him before Amauri; the relationship is now strong and mutual
- 1:1s to find real drivers — the automation three; Catherine's move handled over a coffee, with full support
- **And / nevertheless** instead of **but; when** instead of **if**

PRACTISING UNDERWAY

- Situational leadership — pull first, and daring to **push** when a call must be made (Temi & the senior contractor)
- Delivering firm messages **calmly and factually** — separating the message from the emotion, never from fear
- Entering each conversation deliberately — checking my own state first (the Ben meeting, a blank slate)
- Tailoring **how** each stakeholder wants to be informed — asking their channel and cadence

GROWTH WHERE I'M HEADING

- **Craft vs. timing** — I invest deeply to get things right; my edge is judging how much time a task truly deserves, and protecting focus with an urgent-vs-important sort and a fixed weekly slot for approvals
- **Liked and decisive** — I build trust by making people feel respected; growing to hold a decision firmly once it's made
- **Into the leadership identity** — stepping in with both feet, brave enough to present my authentic self
- **Operative → visionary** — strong on delivery; next, lifting my gaze to where I want to be in three years

What helped most — and a suggestion

Your **value-first** reframing changed the cross-team meeting and the dashboard presentation. Learning to **influence so an idea becomes theirs**. And / **nevertheless** instead of **but**, **when** instead of **if**. Situational leadership — and knowing **when to push, not only pull**. The **iceberg**. And "**name it to tame it**" — the one I reach for most.

— A SUGGESTION — OFFERED WITH PERMISSION, IN THE "I" FORM, LEADING WITH VALUE

“

May I offer one thing, the way you taught me? In my perception, once or twice the lesson arrived while I was still laying out the picture — and the read shifted as more context came out. I'd value finishing the whole picture first, then drawing the lesson together — knowing it may well be intentional.

You received it with grace — and reminded me that **real life hands us fragments, not the full frame**, so reacting well to partial context is a skill in itself. That exchange felt like the method working in both directions.

— 05 TO CLOSE

Three questions for you

| *Does this match what you have in your notes about me?*

| *Where do you see me **differently** from how I see myself?*

| *What's the **single development area** you'd tell me to keep working on after the program ends?*

— IN CLOSING

Thank you, Christiana.

Ten sessions ago I led by task and tightened under feedback. Today I lead with what matters to the other person, I let ideas become theirs, and I meet my own reaction before it speaks.

You didn't hand me techniques — you changed how I show up.

"Be the change." I'll keep the inner work going — and I'll keep in touch.